During the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, the historical 'Great Game' was played out by the British Empire and Czarist Russian Empire on the roof of the world. This was the famous region of the Pamir, Hindukush and the Karakoram ranges where the natural divide of Central and South Asia occurs. This game in a different avatar is being enacted by Pakistan and China against India since 1963, when they colluded and entered into an agreement wherein the Shaksgam valley, a part of India, was 'ceded' by Pakistan to China. This valley covers an area of about 5180 square kilometres and is on the north of the Karakoram range. When seen in the context of the sinister and illegal extension of the LoC from NJ 9842 eastwards to the Karakoram Pass by Pakistan, and the publication in some maps of this interpretation, the rationale of this 'Sino-Pak game' becomes crystal clear. The Shaksgam valley was part of the Dogra kingdom of Jammu and Kashmir, and since the state acceded to India in 1947, it lawfully became a part of our nation. (See Map 11.1 and Panorama 16.1.)

For China it would be more convenient to have the entire Karakoram range in Pakistan's possession right upto the Karakoram Pass, as the ceding of the Shaksgam valley would get sanctified with a higher level of certitude, than if the eastern Karakoram range from Sia La to the famous Karakoram Pass was part of India, and under Indian control. In actual fact, after the decisive victory in the 1971 Indo-Pak war, India had every reason to insist on a settlement of the alignment of the LoC in a northward direction towards the glaciers from NJ 9842 as per the original Karachi agreement of 1949. However, we lost out on that opportunity during the 1972 Shimla talks. According to an engrossing account given by renowned adventurer Harish Kapadia, 'A desperate Bhutto had pleaded with the Indian Prime Minister Indira Gandhi that he be trusted to do so (to agree to delineate the borders along the Saltoro range, but later), as he did not want to antagonize his generals at that point in time. *Aap mujhpe bharosa kijiye* (Trust me), he is reported to have said.'[1]

The Siachen issue gained prominence when cartographic aggression or errors were made in internationally published maps and atlases, which unilaterally decided to mark the extension of the